Using AI tools in research writing

A guide for participants

This guide covers chatbots and other generative AI tools (for example ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude or Copilot) when you write your proposal, your course manuscript or a peer review. It summarises what the main medical publishing bodies and three large publishers require, and links to their official pages. It does not copy them.

Sources checked on 30 October 2026. Policies change often. Before you submit to a journal, read that journal's own instructions for authors.

1. What each body requires

All the pages we could open agree on four points. AI cannot be an author. You are responsible for everything AI produced. You must say that you used AI. Confidential material, such as patient data or a manuscript you review, stays out of public AI tools.

ICMJE Recommendations

Most medical journals follow these recommendations.

- At submission, say whether you used AI tools, and describe how in the cover letter and in the relevant section of the manuscript.
- AI tools cannot be authors. Authors must review and edit AI output, which can be incorrect, incomplete or biased, and make sure AI-produced text and images contain no plagiarism.
- Do not cite AI-generated material as a primary source.
- Reviewers must follow the journal's AI policy or ask permission. Uploading the manuscript to an AI tool is likely prohibited unless the journal allows it and confidentiality is guaranteed. Reviewers who use AI must tell the journal.

Authors: https://www.icmje.org/recommendations/browse/artificial-intelligence/ai-use-by-authors.html

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COPE position statement on authorship and AI tools

COPE (Committee on Publication Ethics) has a position statement on AI tools and authorship. The page could not be opened when we checked the sources, so we do not summarise it here. Read it on the COPE website.

https://publicationethics.org/guidance/cope-position/authorship-and-ai-tools

WAME recommendations on chatbots and generative AI (revised 31 May 2023)

- "Chatbots cannot be authors."
- If a chatbot helped draft text, say so in the acknowledgments. If it did analysis, produced results or figures, or wrote code, say so in the Abstract and Methods, with the tool name and version, the date and the prompt.
- Authors must check that the sources they cite really support their claims.

- Uploading a manuscript to a chatbot breaches confidentiality. Editors and reviewers must disclose any AI use.

https://wame.org/page3.php?id=106

Elsevier (policy updated June 2026)

- Allowed: summarising literature, organising content, improving language and readability, checking completeness against a reporting guideline.
- Not allowed: writing sections without your own intellectual contribution, fabricating or altering data or references, creating or altering primary research images such as scans or patient images.
- Put a separate AI declaration at the end of the manuscript, before the references. Simple grammar and spelling checks need no declaration. AI-made explanatory images (for example a flowchart) must also be declared in the figure caption.
- Reviewers must not upload a manuscript, or any part of it, to an AI tool. Any AI use in a review must be disclosed in the comments to authors.

https://www.elsevier.com/about/policies-and-standards/generative-ai-policies-for-journals

Springer Nature

- AI cannot be an author. Include an AI declaration that names the tool, its purpose and the extent of its contribution.
- Figures made or substantially changed with AI need a note in the caption. Images with no verifiable data behind them are not permitted.
- Confirm that every reference is real and has been checked.
- Reviewers must not paste manuscript text or figures into public AI tools, and must declare AI use. AI must not write the whole review or make the recommendation.

Authors: https://www.springernature.com/gp/policies/editorial-policies/ai-manuscript-preparation

Reviewers: https://www.springernature.com/gp/policies/editorial-policies/using-ai-in-peer-review

JAMA Network (section updated 8 September 2026)

- Report AI use in the Acknowledgment: tool name, version, manufacturer, dates of use, what it did and in which parts of the manuscript. Basic grammar and spelling checkers are exempt.
- Do not use AI to generate or format references. Use a reference manager and check every reference.
- AI-created or AI-altered clinical images are not accepted unless they are part of the research design and fully disclosed.
- Reviewers must not enter confidential manuscripts into a chatbot.

https://jamanetwork.com/journals/jama/pages/instructions-for-authors (section "Use of AI in Publication and Research")

2. In this course

You may use AI to

- improve the language of text you wrote yourself (your proposal, your Results section or your review comments), including turning your Vietnamese draft into English. Then read the result against your own version and correct any change in meaning.

- suggest ideas, an outline or search terms. Then check them in PubMed and in the course materials.
- explain a method or a statistical term, or check your draft against a reporting checklist such as CONSORT or STROBE.

Do not use AI to

- replace you as an author. AI cannot be listed as an author or co-author.
- find, write or format references. Find each one in PubMed yourself and read at least the abstract.
- invent, fill in or change data, numbers or results. Every number in your Results section comes from your own analysis output. Check each one again against your tables.
- create or alter figures, tables of results, or images of patients or scans.
- process patient data or any confidential data in a public AI tool, even with names removed.
- read or judge a manuscript you are reviewing. Do not paste a classmate's draft, or any part of it, into an AI tool. The judgement in your review must be your own.

3. How to disclose

Give the **tool name and version**, the **company**, the **dates** you used it, **what** it did and **which sections** it touched. Keep your prompts and the AI output in case an editor asks for them.

- **In this course:** one line at the end of your proposal or manuscript, starting with "AI use:". If you did not use AI, write "AI use: none".
- **In a journal:** follow that journal's instructions. Depending on the journal it goes in the Acknowledgment, the Methods, a separate AI declaration or the cover letter.

Example:

> AI use: I used ChatGPT (OpenAI, version [name]) on 2 to 9 December 2026 to improve the English of the Introduction and Discussion. I checked and edited all the text and take full responsibility for it. No AI tool was used for the analysis, the figures or the references.

4. Before you submit

- Every reference exists, says what you say it says, and you found it yourself.
- Every number in the text matches your own analysis output and tables.
- No patient data, confidential data or manuscript under review went into a public AI tool.
- Your disclosure names the tool, version, dates, purpose and sections.
- You can explain and defend every sentence in your own words.